

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

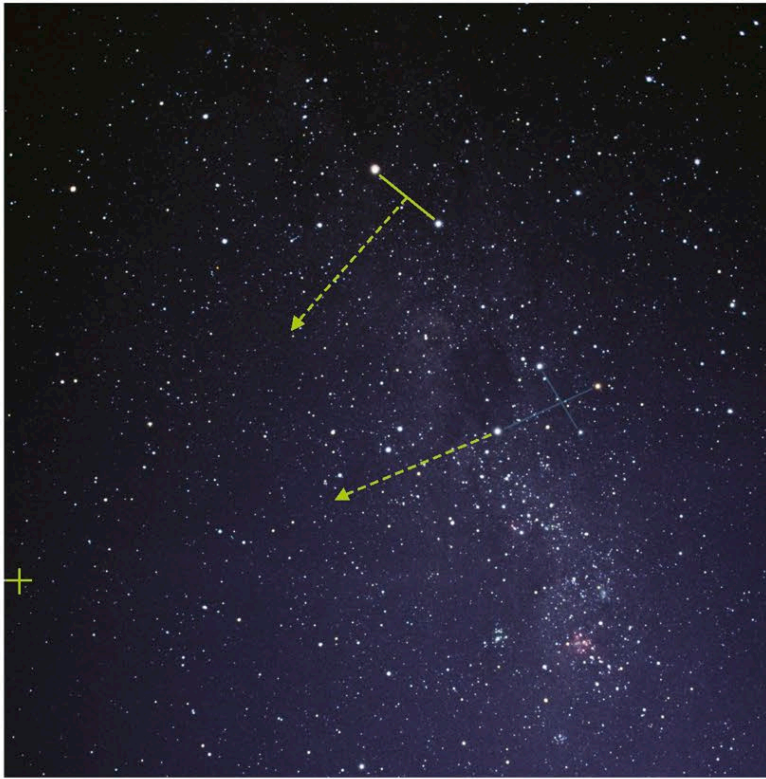
Sirius (see p.252) and Canopus, the two brightest stars in the entire sky, remain high for southern observers throughout February, while Achernar, the 1st-magnitude star at the end of the celestial river Eridanus, sinks toward the southwestern horizon. In the southeast, Crux, the Southern Cross, enters the scene, followed by the bright stars of Centaurus. Higher up is the False Cross, which is formed by four stars in Vela and Carina and is sometimes mistaken for the true Southern Cross.

Due north lie Castor (see p.276) and Pollux in Gemini. Orion is also high in the sky, with Taurus lower in the northwest. As seen from the most southerly latitudes, Perseus has already set and Auriga is following. Meanwhile, looking northeast, the distinctive shape of Leo, the Lion, has come into view.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

The Milky Way, which meanders from southeast to northwest this month, contains numerous star clusters, of which M46 and M47, adjacent in Puppis, are prominent. Both clusters are at the edge of naked-eye visibility and look superb through binoculars. Two other open clusters that can be seen excellently through binoculars are NGC 2451 and NGC 2477, also in Puppis; farther south, in Vela, IC 2391 and IC 2395 are also good examples.

Outside the boundaries of the Milky Way, the open cluster M41 is found south of Sirius, while in the north, the Beehive Cluster (see p.290), or M44, is well positioned for observation in both February and March. In Carina, another open cluster, NGC 2516, is prominent. The Large Magellanic Cloud and the Tarantula Nebula are on view, south of Canopus, in the constellation Dorado.



FINDING THE SOUTH CELESTIAL POLE

The south celestial pole (left) is not marked by a bright star, but it can be located by intersecting two imaginary lines. One is the extension of the long axis of Crux. The other is at right angles to the line joining Alpha (α) and Beta (β) Centauri.

URANUS

